Francesco Billari

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Research Interests: Applied Microeconomics, Public Economics, Political Economy, Industrial Organization

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Cornell University, ILR School Jul 2026–present
Postdoctoral Associate

EDUCATION

Cornell University
PhD in Economics Aug 2019–May 2026

Bocconi University
Master of Science in Economics Sep 2015–Jul 2018
Bachelor of Science in Economics Sep 2011–Sep 2014

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Cornell University August 2020–May 2026
Research Assistant, Prof. Marco Battaglini
Bocconi University June 2017–Dec 2017
Research Assistant, Prof. Pierpaolo Battigalli

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Cornell University
Instructor, ILRID 2660 – Essential Desktop Applications (five sections) Fall 2026
Teaching Assistant, ECON 1110 – Introductory Microeconomics Fall 2020, 2022, Spring 2026
Teaching Assistant, ECON 3030 – Intermediate Microeconomics Fall 2025
Teaching Assistant, ECON 3130 – Statistics and Probability Fall 2023
Teaching Assistant, ECON 3120 – Applied Econometrics Spring 2023
Teaching Assistant, ECON 6200 – Econometrics II Spring 2021, 2022
Teaching Assistant, ECON 3830 – Economics of Consumer Protection Fall 2021

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Cornell University
Manager, ILR Computer Lab (team of eight lab consultants), ILR School 2026–present
Head Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics Aug 2023–Aug 2024

AWARDS AND FELLOWSHIPS

Dissertation-Year Sage Doctoral Fellowship, Cornell University 2024–2025
Howard and Abby Milstein Graduate Teaching Assistantship Award, Cornell University 2022
Rob Lynch Prize (Distinction in First-Year PhD Econometrics), Cornell University 2020
First-Year Sage Doctoral Fellowship, Cornell University 2019–2020

SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

Public Economics Workshop – Cornell University 2025
Third-Year PhD Conference – Cornell University 2022

RESEARCH PAPERS

Don't Try Again: Screening Through Attempt Limits Job Market Paper
Using mechanism design, I model attempt limits on licensing and civil-service exams as a device for screening candidates' skills through the dynamic allocation of testing opportunities. A limit grants a single attempt but lets candidates choose when to use it: high-skilled candidates take the test at once, while low-skilled ones postpone it and acquire skills in the meantime. The limit sorts candidates before testing them, but it is incentive compatible only if the test is not too lenient. I characterize when it is the optimal testing policy, together with the leniency and accuracy of the test. Consistent with the model, attempt limits on the U.S. bar exam are tightest at intermediate passing scores and rare where the exam is lenient.

Media Capture in Local News Markets Working paper
This paper studies how the revenue structure of local news outlets affects political bias. In a Bayesian persuasion model, a monopolist outlet chooses between advertising and subscription income and may be captured by the incumbent. I show that the relationship between advertising revenues and bias is generally inverted-U shaped: when per-reader advertising revenues are low, as after the entry of online platforms into advertising markets, a further decline raises subscription prices, leads readers to demand more informative coverage, and reduces pro-incumbent bias.

Work in Progress

Competition among Licensing Authorities
How competition among jurisdictions for mobile professionals shapes attempt limits, passing standards, and the value of portable test scores.

Why Do Attempt Limits Raise Passing Rates? A Quantitative Analysis
A dynamic model of repeated attempts, calibrated to U.S. bar exam data, that decomposes the effect of attempt limits into the exclusion of candidates who exhaust their attempts and candidates' responses to the limit.

Visual Media Bias: Evidence from Computer Vision and Machine Learning Note
Whether newspapers use less flattering photographs of politicians from the opposing party, measured with computer vision and identified from the moment a candidate becomes the presumptive nominee.

PROFESSIONAL SKILLS

Software: SQL, Python, R, Stata, Matlab, Mathematica, Excel, LaTeX
Languages: Italian (native), English (fluent), German (basic)

PROFESSIONAL CERTIFICATES

SQL for Data Science Capstone Project, University of California, Davis Sep 2026
SQL Problem Solving, University of California, Davis Sep 2026
SQL for Data Science, University of California, Davis Aug 2026
Data Science series, edX (eight verified certificates) Jun–Jul 2026
Building Machine Learning Models, Linear Regression, Wrangling, Productivity Tools, Inference and Modeling, Probability, Visualization, R Basics

WORK AUTHORIZATION

Currently authorized to work in the U.S. on F-1 Optional Practical Training (OPT); eligible for the 24-month STEM OPT extension

REFERENCES

Marco Battaglini
Edward H. Meyer Professor of Economics
Cornell University
mb2457@cornell.edu

Stephen Coate
Kiplinger Professor of Public Policy
Cornell University
sc163@cornell.edu

Tommaso Denti
Assistant Professor of Economics
Stern School of Business – NYU
td838@stern.nyu.edu